

Places to Visit in Sikkim

1. Gurudongmar Lake (North Sikkim)

Gurudongmar Lake is one of the **highest lakes in the world**, located at an altitude of **5,430 meters (17,800 feet)** above sea level. Nestled in the **Great Himalayas** within the **Mangan District** of North Sikkim, this lake is not only a visual wonder but also holds **deep religious significance**. It is revered by both **Buddhists and Sikhs**, and is named after **Guru Padmasambhava**, who is believed to have visited the area in the **8th century**. The surrounding area remains snow-covered during most of the year, making it a breathtaking destination, especially for those interested in **spiritual tourism and high-altitude adventure**.

2. Chardham (South Sikkim - Namchi)

The **Chardham pilgrimage site**, located at **Solophok Hill** about **5 km from Namchi town**, is a grand spiritual complex in **South Sikkim**. At the heart of the complex stands a **towering 108-foot statue of Lord Shiva**, which is surrounded by replicas of the **four sacred Dhams** of India – **Badrinath (North), Dwarka (West), Jagannath (East), and Rameshwaram (South)**. The belief is that a visit to this site is equivalent to undertaking the original Chardham Yatra across India. It is a perfect blend of spirituality, architecture, and panoramic views of the hills.

3. Barsey Rhododendron Sanctuary (West Sikkim)

Located in the **West Sikkim District**, the **Barsey Rhododendron Sanctuary** spans **104 sq. km** and is a vital **biodiversity corridor** linking the **Khangchendzonga Biosphere Reserve (KBR)** in the north to the **Singalila National Park** of West Bengal in the south. The sanctuary is best visited during the **spring season (March to May)** when the forest blooms with a spectacular array of **rhododendrons** and other alpine flora. Trekking is a popular activity here, offering serene trails through **lush forests, moss-covered paths, and breathtaking mountain views**. It is also home to endangered species like the **Red Panda**.

4. Buddha Park / Tathagata Tsal (South Sikkim - Ravangla)

The **Buddha Park of Ravangla**, also known as **Tathagata Tsal**, is a spiritual and scenic park located in **South Sikkim**, near **Ravangla town**. Constructed between **2006 and 2013**, the park features a magnificent **130-foot-high (40 meters) statue of Gautama Buddha**. It was inaugurated to commemorate the **2550th birth anniversary of Lord Buddha**. The statue is surrounded by beautifully landscaped gardens, meditation spaces, and a museum that narrates the life and teachings of Buddha. Set against the backdrop of the **Himalayas**, it offers a **peaceful retreat and cultural experience**.